Redesigning Airline Checkout Donations: Increasing Real-Money Giving in Three Simulated Booking Experiments

Hunter Delaney and Craig Fellers, Ph.D.

Better Behavior Foundation, Santa Cruz, California, United States

Author Note

Craig Fellers https://orcid.org/0000-0001-5836-9191

The authors have no conflicts of interest to declare. This research was supported by a grant from the Center for Behavior and Climate through its behavior change for climate action challenge 2025 program. The authors thank Cameron Gordon for his contributions in experiment design and his support.

Hunter Delaney played a lead role in investigation, data curation, analysis, visualization, and writing–original draft, and a supporting role in conceptualization and methodology. Craig Fellers played a lead role in conceptualization, methodology, project administration, supervision, and writing–review and editing.

Anonymized data are available on the Open Science Framework at https://osf.io/n47z2/.

Correspondence concerning this article should be addressed to Craig Fellers, Better Behavior Foundation, 633 Ramona Ave., Space 103, Los Osos, CA 93402, United States. Email: craig.fellers@gmail.com

Redesigning Airline Checkout Donations: Increasing Real-Money Giving in Three Simulated Booking Experiments

Abstract

Purpose – Many airlines ask customers to donate to a cause at checkout, but few people give. This study tested whether redesigning the donation request increases real giving.

Design/methodology/approach – Across three experiments (N = 1,683), participants completed a simulated flight booking with TUI, British Airways or Aegean Airlines. They saw either the airline's existing donation request or a redesigned request with an image of the cause, information about other donors, and a statement of where the money goes. Donations were real: any amount given came out of an allowance that participants otherwise kept.

Findings – The redesigned request increased the share of participants who donated in all three experiments. Across baseline conditions, 17.8–19.3% of participants chose to donate a portion of their earnings. With a redesigned donation feature, 26.4–41.8% chose to donate. Differences in brand perception between groups did not reach statistical significance.

Originality – Most research on climate giving in air travel measures what people report they would pay. The current results show that a better request at the moment of booking increases consequential giving in simulated airline bookings.

Keywords

Sustainable tourism; Pro-environmental behavior; Choice architecture; Charitable giving; Climate contributions; Consequential giving

Introduction

Airlines face growing pressure to improve sustainability, and most are falling short of customer expectations. Across 17 countries around the world, 59% of consumers said airlines were not doing enough to reduce their environmental impact. Only 17% said they were doing enough, the lowest rating given to any industry in that survey (YouGov, 2023). Sustainable aviation fuel remains years from meaningful scale. It is expected to deliver roughly 65% of the emissions reductions aviation needs to reach net zero by 2050, yet it still accounts for less than 1% of global aviation fuel use and costs several times more than conventional jet fuel. Its implementation is held back by limited feedstock, production technology that is still developing, missing infrastructure, and large upfront capital requirements (International Air Transport Association, 2026). Carbon offsetting draws skepticism from consumers and regulators alike, and the record supports the skepticism. A synthesis of 2,346 crediting projects, covering almost a billion tons of CO_2e, estimated that less than 16% of the credits issued to the investigated projects represented real emissions reductions; the corresponding estimate for avoided-deforestation projects was approximately 25% (Probst *et al.*, 2024).

Climate contributions provide a viable alternative to achieve near-term sustainability gains in the airline industry. Reforestation and forest preservation have been identified by the IPCC as cost-effective, scalable methods of carbon sequestration (Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change, 2022). On top of capturing carbon, protected forests conserve biodiversity, improve water regulation, and build climate resilience. Between 2001 and 2019, global forests absorbed about twice as much CO_2 as they emitted, a net carbon sink of approximately 7.6 billion tons of CO_2 each year (Harris *et al.*, 2021). For example, Brazil's Menkragnotí Indigenous reserve absorbs about 10 million tons of CO_2 more than it emits each year, whereas adjacent unprotected lands have become net emitters (Harris *et al.*, 2021).

Unlike carbon offsets, climate contributions are not commoditized and traded in a way that encourages over-crediting. A contribution funds conservation work without being subtracted from the airline's own emissions total, which reduces the incentive to inflate the climate benefit claimed for a project (Blanchard *et al.*, 2024). Climate contributions are generally optimized for their environmental impact and managed by reputable non-profits looking to preserve forests rather than maximize their token value for trading. Climate contributions provide a concrete way for passengers to act on climate concerns, while providing a clear message to airlines that consumers demand sustainability and are willing to pay for it. Currently, airlines have little market signal to prioritize sustainability measures.

Passengers report that they would pay to address their flights' emissions. In SITA's 2022 survey, more than 90% of passengers expressed willingness to pay extra to offset their flight's emissions, with an average stated willingness to pay 10.7% of the ticket price (SITA, 2022). Yet when an undisclosed airline gave 63,520 real customers that opportunity, only 4.5% of customers were willing to pay (Berger *et al.*, 2022). This gap motivates testing whether the design of the donation request can increase actual giving. We therefore treat the donation feature itself as the experimental object, redesigning the donation prompt in its entirety while holding the purchase context constant (Thaler and Sunstein, 2008).

The Levers of the Donation Request

Social information can help people decide how to act (Goldstein *et al.*, 2008), imagery can make the cause vivid and concrete (White *et al.*, 2019), and transparency can reduce

doubt about where the money goes (Gneezy *et al.*, 2014). The current research combined these elements in a redesigned donation feature. It tests the redesign as a package and does not identify the separate contribution of any one element.

The amount requested and the way the choice is presented are also part of the redesigned package. Larger suggested amounts can raise gift size while lowering uptake (De Bruyn and Prokopec, 2013), and defaults can shift decisions (Johnson and Goldstein, 2003), although a request should not make customers feel pressured at checkout (Zou *et al.*, 2026).

A research-informed donation feature gives airlines something they can test and improve using live checkout and payment systems which are already in place. This makes the moment of booking an immediate opportunity to turn stated support for climate action into real giving.

The Current Research

We report three experiments run in realistic simulated booking flows testing a redesigned donation feature against the live feature at the time of this study for three large airlines. We chose Touristik Union International (TUI), British Airways, and Aegean Airlines as examples of airlines that already offered checkout donation features. Both the Baseline and Redesigned conditions reproduced a full multi-page booking with seat selection, add-ons, and a running price total. Both booking flows ended with the donation request feature.

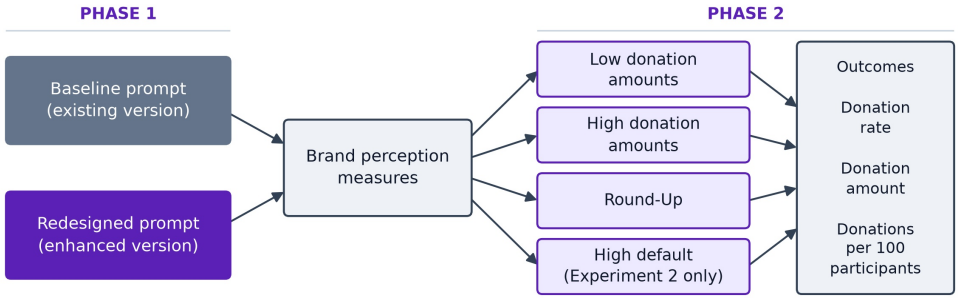
The present research evaluates the proposition that behaviorally informed redesign of airline checkout donation requests can increase opt-in rates for charitable giving. A second, hypothetical phase of each experiment explored larger and round-up requests (Kelting *et al.*, 2019). Secondary analyses assess whether increased charitable participation is accompanied by changes in airline brand perceptions and explore participants' preferred charitable causes. Together, these studies examine the effectiveness, fundraising implications, and consumer acceptability of redesigned airline donation requests.

Method

This study was conducted independently, not under an institution requiring Institutional Review Board (IRB) review. The research involved a minimal-risk online experiment with adult participants. The study did not target vulnerable populations or collect sensitive information, and it involved no interventions presenting more than minimal risk. This online study was designed and conducted in accordance with generally accepted ethical principles for research involving human participants, including voluntary participation, consent, minimization of risk, and the right to discontinue participation at any time. Anonymized data are available on the Open Science Framework at https://osf.io/n47z2/.

Each experiment was divided into two phases. Phase 1 donation decisions were made with real financial consequences. Participants were paid for taking part in the study. The expected earnings for participation in this study were guaranteed and paid out to every participant regardless of their choice regarding donations. In addition to the advertised payment, participants were given an allowance that they could either spend or keep depending on how they answered questions in the study. Before starting, participants were told that if they chose to donate within the experiment, the amount they chose to donate would be sent to the organization as shown in the booking flow. If they chose not to donate, their allowance would be paid out to them at the end of the study. These payments were paid out as described upon completion. Using this method, the donation became a real financial decision for each participant; a participant who donated £2 earned £2 less for the session than one who declined to donate and kept the money. All Phase 1 outcomes therefore reflect donation decisions with real financial consequences. After Phase 1, participants answered the brand perception questions and then completed a second booking with the same airline (Phase 2). Phase 2 donations were hypothetical. Participants were told their response would not affect their payment and were asked to respond as they would in a real booking.

Figure 1
Two-phase study design.



Within each phase, participants were randomly assigned between conditions. Phase 1 compared Baseline and Redesigned conditions; Experiment 2 included two redesigned conditions differing in response requirement and amount highlighting. After the Phase 1 booking, participants completed brand perception measures, then were randomly assigned to a group in Phase 2 with a second booking. Outcomes were donation rate, donation amount among donors, and projected donations per 100 participants.

Booking Flows. The three airlines (TUI, British Airways, and Aegean Airlines) were chosen from a larger set of airline checkouts we reviewed. They were representative of the low-salience donation prompts typical of the industry. Each booking flow was reconstructed by capturing the live site's pages through the browser's inspect-element tool and rebuilding their layout and behavior as custom HTML and JavaScript in the Qualtrics editor, reproducing the Baseline flow the airline used at the time of the experiment. The layout captures were taken between April and June 2026, and every description of a Baseline prompt in this paper refers to the airline's checkout as it stood then.

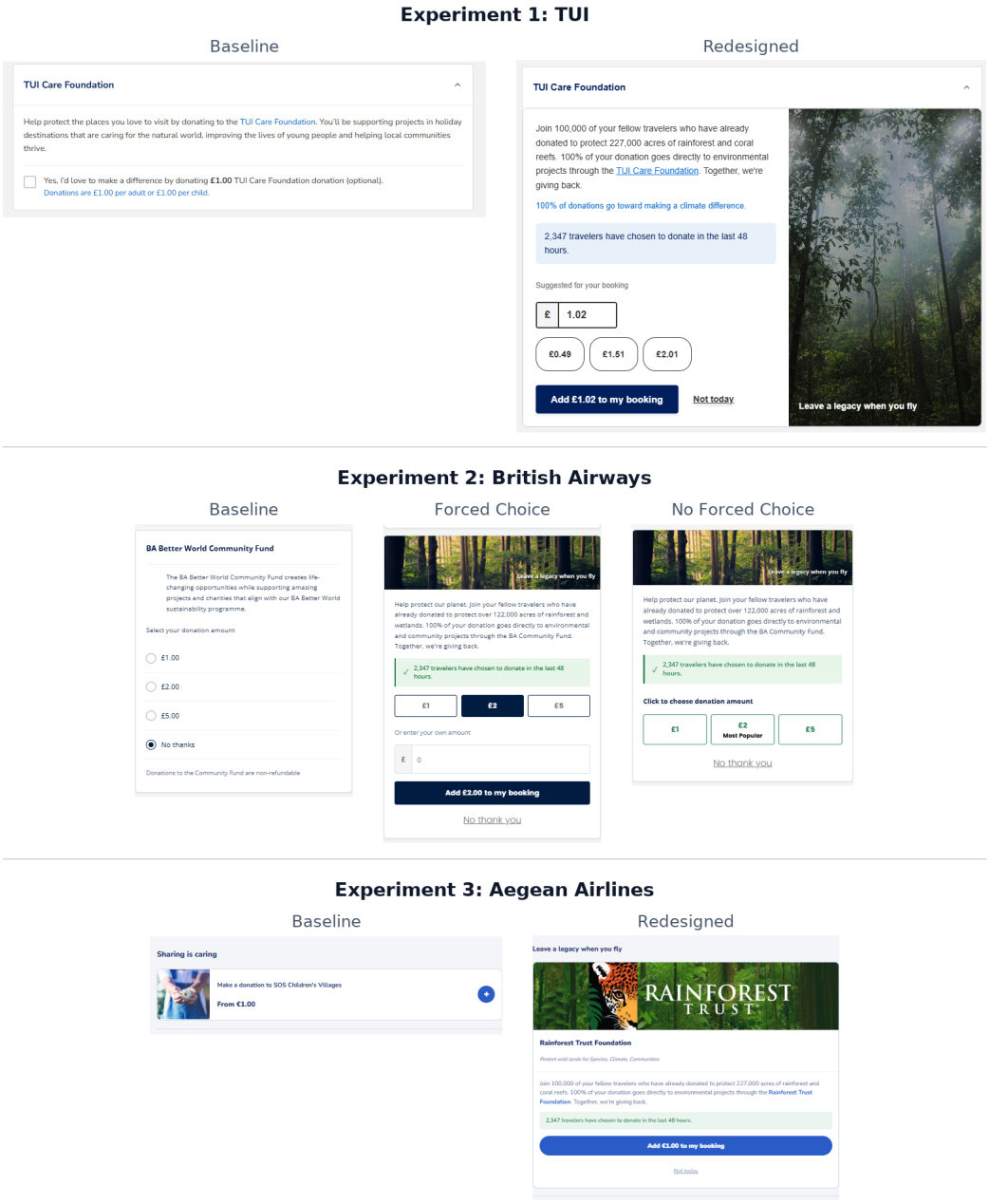
Design and Procedure. Both phases were randomized between subjects (Figure 1). Phase 1 assigned participants to a Baseline or Redesigned condition; Experiment 2 included two redesigned conditions. All participants received information about the study and compensation, confirmed that they were over 18 years old, and indicated consent by clicking to proceed. Participation was voluntary and participants could discontinue the study at any time without penalty while retaining compensation. Instructions were then provided about their allowance that they could choose to keep or donate and how their decisions had real financial consequences, as detailed above.

All participants initiated the booking simulation by choosing the pre-selected flight. Then they advanced to the seat selection page, the baggage upgrade page, and the insurance selection page. Continuing to follow the live booking flow, on the next page, the Baseline group was given the airline's own donation request, as it appeared at the time of capture. Upon advancing to the donation page, the Redesigned group was shown the redesigned donation feature. For each of the three experiments, the redesigned donation feature was designed to take an analogous form to what was live on the airline website. For this reason, the redesigned features differed slightly in button layout and requested donation amounts. However, all three redesigned features made use of the same behavioral elements. Each redesign was presented as a complete redesign package, and the experiments were not designed to isolate the contribution from any single design element. After Phase 1, participants rated four brand perception measures on a 1–7 Likert scale (favorability, future booking, consideration when not cheapest, and willingness to book). The full wording of all four items is reproduced in the Appendix.

In Phase 2, participants were randomized to one of three groups (four in Experiment 2). All participants went through the same booking process from Phase 1 with the donation feature being the only change participants experienced in the booking flow. Participants in each group saw the Phase 1 redesigned feature that varied the suggested amounts or their presentation, and were told that their choices to give would be hypothetical. Groups included a Low-Amount group that matched the Phase 1 redesign, a High-Amount group, and a Round-Up group asked to round the booking total up to the next multiple of 10 in the booking currency. Including the Low-Amount group allowed for a comparison of consequential and hypothetical donation decisions while keeping the donation-request design and offered amounts constant.

Measures and Analysis. Donation opt-in (coded 1 for a donation and 0 otherwise) was compared with Welch's t-tests for two groups and one-way ANOVAs for three or more groups, with Cohen's d and η^2 as effect sizes. Pairwise contrasts among the three Phase 1 groups in Experiment 2 were Holm-adjusted. Projected donations per 100 participants were calculated with non-donors assigned zero. Although we were not able to control for order, as an exploratory analysis, we compared hypothetical and consequential giving with a hypothetical-to-real ratio: the donation opt-in rate of the Low-Amount group in Phase 2 divided by that of the Redesigned group in Phase 1 (the Forced Choice condition in Experiment 2). A ratio of 1 indicates equal opt-in with and without real money at stake. The hypothetical decision always followed the consequential one, so the ratio is reported descriptively. The four brand items were averaged into a composite brand perception score. Responses were screened before analysis, and donation amounts above 1,000 in the booking currency were excluded as potential data-entry errors (one entry, Experiment 2). Brand perception items were collected before Phase 2 and are analyzed by the Phase 1 group only.

Figure 2
Phase 1 donation prompts as participants saw them in each experiment.



Top: TUI, a £1.00 optional checkbox (Baseline) and the redesigned prompt with £0.49/£1.51/£2.01 presets and a £1.02 default (Redesigned). Middle: British Airways, a £1/£2/£5 selector with "No thanks" pre-selected (Baseline); the redesigned prompt with £2 highlighted and a required response (Forced Choice); and the same prompt with nothing highlighted (No Forced Choice). Bottom: Aegean Airlines, an SOS Children's Villages pop-up with a fixed €1.00 checkbox (Baseline) and the Rainforest Trust prompt with the same €1.00 request (Redesigned).

Experiment 1: TUI

Method

Participants. Prolific participants (N = 485) started the survey; 481 completed Phase 1 (242 Baseline, 239 Redesigned) and 480 completed Phase 2. The 4 participants who did not complete Phase 1 left the survey before reaching the donation feature and are not included in any analysis. Median completion time was 3.57 minutes.

Materials. The booking flow reproduced TUI's online site and utilized a flight with a base fare of £496 plus the option for seat and luggage add-ons. The charity for the donation request was the TUI Care Foundation, the travel group's charitable foundation, which funds environmental and community projects. The donation prompt appeared on the Airport Extras

page. The Baseline donation request was a £1.00 optional donation checkbox. The Redesigned group was presented with the updated donation feature but with a donation menu centered around the requested amount (see Figure 2). The changes in design elements were tested as a single combined variable. The redesigned feature included a banner image of a rainforest carrying the caption "Leave a legacy when you fly." The prompt also included an impact statement, '100% of your donation goes directly to environmental projects,' to provide transparency about where donations would go. Social-proof appeals read "Join 100,000 of your fellow travelers who have already donated to protect 227,000 acres of rainforest and coral reefs" and "2,347 travelers have chosen to donate in the last 48 hours." Donor counts were not publicly available, so the prompt used plausible values informed by figures displayed on comparable websites, such as Air Canada's donation feature. The reported protected-area estimate was calculated based on publicly available information on the TUI Care Foundation website. Finally, the prompt offered preset amounts of £0.49, £1.51, and £2.01 alongside a free-text amount field (default £1.02). The default amount of £1.02 was chosen to be similar to the Baseline donation amount while giving an additional level of precision, because unusual, non-round request amounts have been found to draw attention to a request and increase compliance (Lee and Feeley, 2017; Santos *et al.*, 1994). Participants in both groups had to choose whether to donate or not; participants could not continue the booking without accepting or declining the donation, ensuring every participant interacted with the donation feature. After completing the checkout process, participants were shown the four brand perception questions.

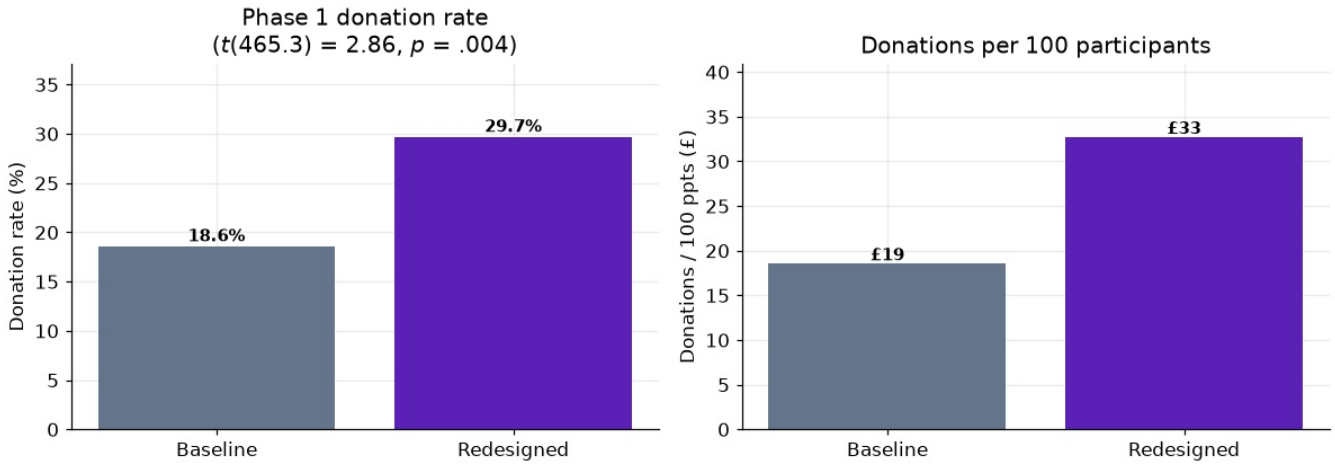
Phase 2. The Low-Amount group repeated the Phase 1 redesigned request (presets of £0.49, £1.51, and £2.01, with a free-text field opening at £1.02). The High-Amount group offered £1, £20, and £30, with the field opening at £10.00. The Round-Up group was offered only the amount that rounded the booking total up to the next multiple of £10, usually £5, which participants could accept or decline. All three groups were forced-choice.

Results

Phase 1. The Redesigned donation feature raised the donation rate from 18.6% to 29.7%, an increase of 11.1 percentage points, $t(465.3) = 2.86$, $p = .004$, $d = 0.26$ (Figure 3). Mean donation among donors was £1.00 in the Baseline group and £1.10 in the Redesigned group.

Figure 3

Experiment 1: Phase 1 donation rate and donations per 100 participants.



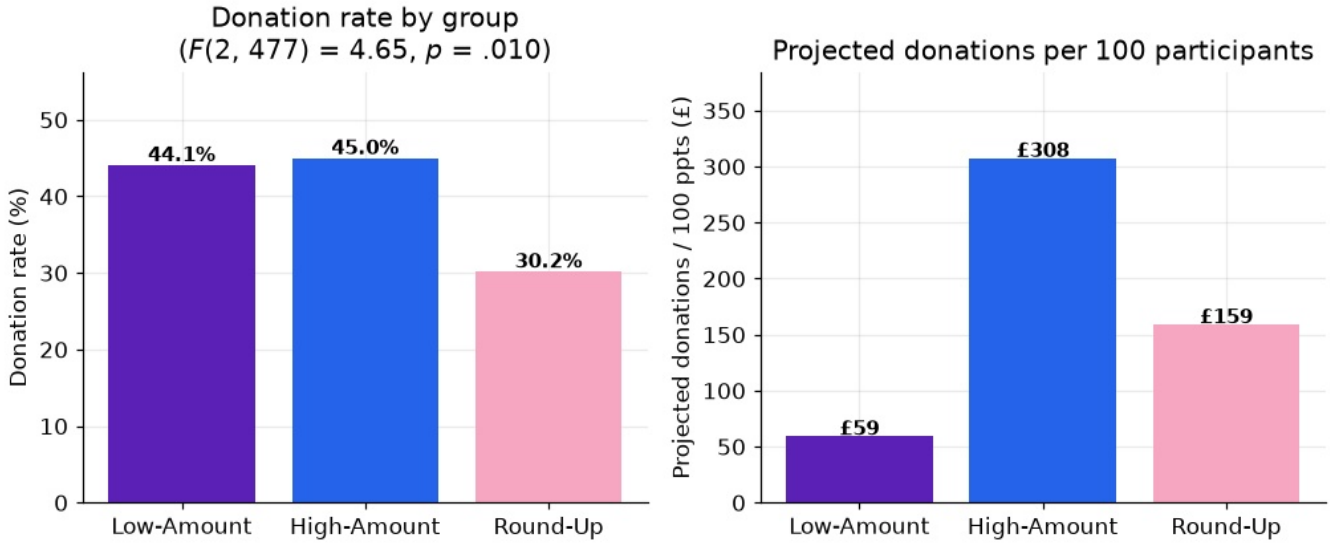
Baseline $n = 242$, Redesigned $n = 239$. Tests are described in Measures and Analysis.

Brand Perception Measures. The difference in composite brand perception between the Baseline and Redesigned groups did not reach statistical significance (4.34 vs 4.41), $t(477.6) = 0.79$, $p = .429$, $d = 0.07$.

Phase 2. Donation rates were 44.1% for Low-Amount, 45.0% for High-Amount, and 30.2% for Round-Up, $F(2, 477) = 4.65$, $p = .010$, $\eta^2 = .02$ (Figure 4). Projected donations per 100 participants were £59.41, £307.60, and £159.12. Projected donations per 100 participants were 5.18 times as high in the High-Amount group as in the Low-Amount group. The calculated hypothetical-to-real donation ratio was 1.48. This means that the proportion opting to donate was 1.48 times as high in the Phase 2 Low-Amount group as in the Phase 1 Redesigned group, where donation decisions had real financial consequences (44.1% versus 29.7%).

Figure 4

Experiment 1: Phase 2 donation rate and projected donations per 100 participants by group.



Low-Amount = £0.49/£1.51/£2.01 with £1.02 default; High-Amount = £1/£20/£30 with £10.00 default; Round-Up = booking total rounded up to the next multiple of £10 (usually £5). Low-Amount n = 161, High-Amount n = 160, Round-Up n = 159.

Experiment 2: British Airways

Method

Participants. A total of 774 Prolific participants took part in Experiment 2 and were divided into the three groups. Of these, 719 completed Phase 1 (241 Baseline, 239 Forced Choice, 239 No Forced Choice) and 706 completed Phase 2. The remaining 55 left the survey before reaching the Phase 1 donation prompt and were removed; they contributed no Phase 1 data, so were not included in any analysis. The 13 participants who completed Phase 1 but left before finishing Phase 2 are counted in the Phase 1 results and excluded from Phase 2. Median completion time was 4.33 minutes.

Materials. The simulated booking flow reproduced that found on BA's website (London to Munich, £295); the charity was the BA Better World Community Fund. The donation features appeared on the Review and Pay page. The Baseline donation feature mirrored BA's payment-page request, offering £1, £2, £5, and "No thanks" as response options. As on BA's site at the time of capture, "No thanks" was preselected, and participants were not required to respond. If they continued without interacting with the donation feature, no donation was made.

The Forced Choice and No Forced Choice groups saw the same redesigned donation feature with the same £1/£2/£5 amounts, imagery, and social information. In the Forced Choice group, £2 was highlighted within the £1/£2/£5 menu, but the participant had to choose to either add a donation or decline donating before proceeding. They could click from the highlighted £2 to the £1 or £5 before choosing whether or not to donate if desired. In the No Forced Choice group, no amount was highlighted and the participants were free to proceed without responding; if they did not engage with the donation feature, no donation was selected by default. See Figure 2.

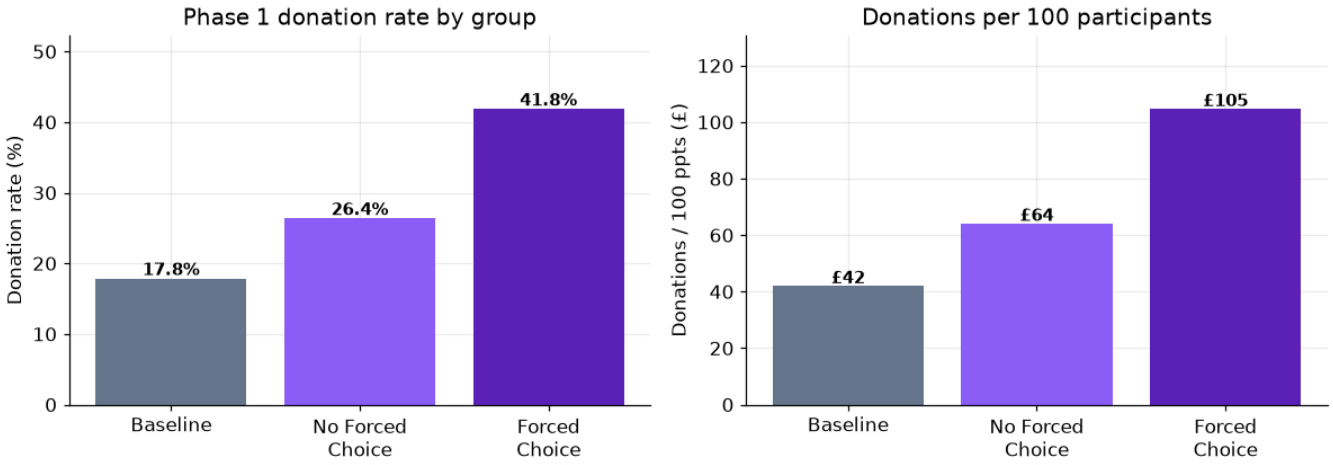
Phase 2. Four groups saw the redesigned feature with different amounts: Low-Amount, as in Phase 1 (£1/£2/£5, £2 highlighted); High-Amount (£3/£10/£30, £10 highlighted); Round-Up (£5, rounding the £295 total up to £300); and High-Default (£1/£2/£5, £5 highlighted). All were forced-choice.

Results

Phase 1. Donation opt-in differed across the three groups, with rates of 17.8% for Baseline, 26.4% for No Forced Choice, and 41.8% for Forced Choice, $F(2, 716) = 18.17$, $p < .001$, $\eta^2 = .05$ (Figure 5). No Forced Choice increased opt-in compared to Baseline by 8.5 percentage points, $t(467.8) = 2.26$, Holm-adjusted $p = .025$, $d = 0.21$. The opt-in rate in the Forced Choice group was 15.5 percentage points higher than in the No Forced Choice group, $t(470.0) = 3.61$, Holm-adjusted $p < .001$, $d = 0.33$. Compared with Baseline, the Forced Choice condition increased donation opt-in by 24.0 percentage points, $t(448.5) = 5.94$, Holm-adjusted $p < .001$, $d = 0.54$. Mean donation among donors was £2.35 for the Baseline group, £2.43 for No Forced Choice, and £2.50 for Forced Choice.

Figure 5

Experiment 2: Phase 1 donation rate and donations per 100 participants by group.



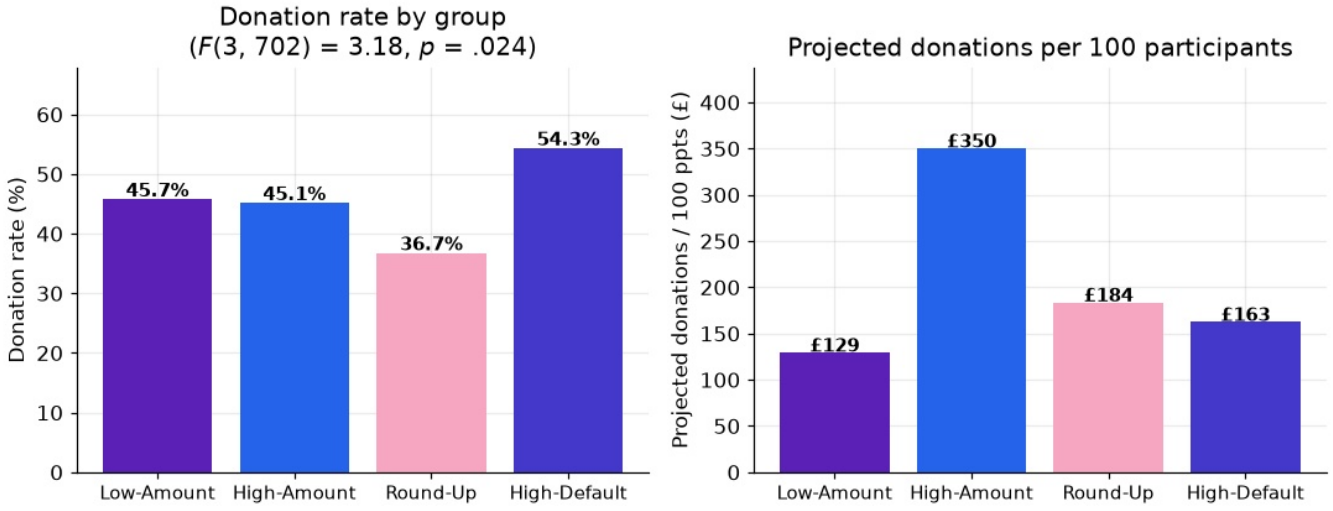
Baseline n = 241, No Forced Choice n = 239, Forced Choice n = 239. Forced Choice combined a required response with a highlighted £2; its contrast with No Forced Choice does not separate these features.

Brand Perception Measures. The difference in composite brand perception score did not reach statistical significance (4.52 for Baseline, 4.47 for Forced Choice, and 4.69 for No Forced Choice), $F(2, 711) = 2.71$, $p = .067$, $\eta^2 = .01$.

Phase 2. Donation rates were 45.7% for Low-Amount, 45.1% for High-Amount, 36.7% for Round-Up, and 54.3% for High-Default, $F(3, 702) = 3.18$, $p = .024$, $\eta^2 = .01$ (Figure 6). Projected donations per 100 participants were £129.40, £350.26, £183.67, and £162.61. Projected donations per 100 participants were 2.71 times as high in High-Amount as in Low-Amount. The calculated hypothetical-to-real donation ratio was 1.09.

Figure 6

Experiment 2: Phase 2 donation rate and projected donations per 100 participants by group.



Low-Amount = £1/£2/£5 with £2 highlighted; High-Amount = £3/£10/£30 with £10 highlighted; Round-Up = booking total rounded up to the next multiple of £10 (£5 here); High-Default = £1/£2/£5 with £5 highlighted. Its monetary estimate uses n = 115 because one participant lacked a valid monetary observation.

Experiment 3: Aegean Airlines

Method

Participants. Prolific participants (N = 493) started the survey; 483 completed Phase 1 (243 Baseline, 240 Redesigned) and 477 completed Phase 2. The 10 participants who did not complete Phase 1 left the survey before reaching the donation feature and are not included in any analysis. Median completion time was 4.00 minutes.

Materials. The survey flow simulated what was live on Aegean Airlines's booking site (€225 fare plus €30 seat,

€255 subtotal, with clickable extras priced in multiples of €10). The donation prompt was shown on the Enhance Your Trip page. Participants were randomly assigned into one of two groups. Matching Aegean's live website, the Baseline group was shown a donation feature consisting of a pop-up window naming SOS Children's Villages with a checkbox reading "I wish to donate the amount of €1.00." The Redesigned group saw an updated donation feature asking for a donation to the Rainforest Trust Foundation. The updated charity, banner image, tagline, and social information were presented together as a single redesign package. As in Experiments 1 and 2, participants were told that any selected donation amounts would be paid to that charity from the allowance given at the beginning of the study. Neither the Baseline nor the Redesigned donation prompt was forced-choice; a participant could continue the booking without responding, and doing so donated nothing.

In this experiment, after completing Phase 2, participants were asked two additional questions about their charitable preferences.

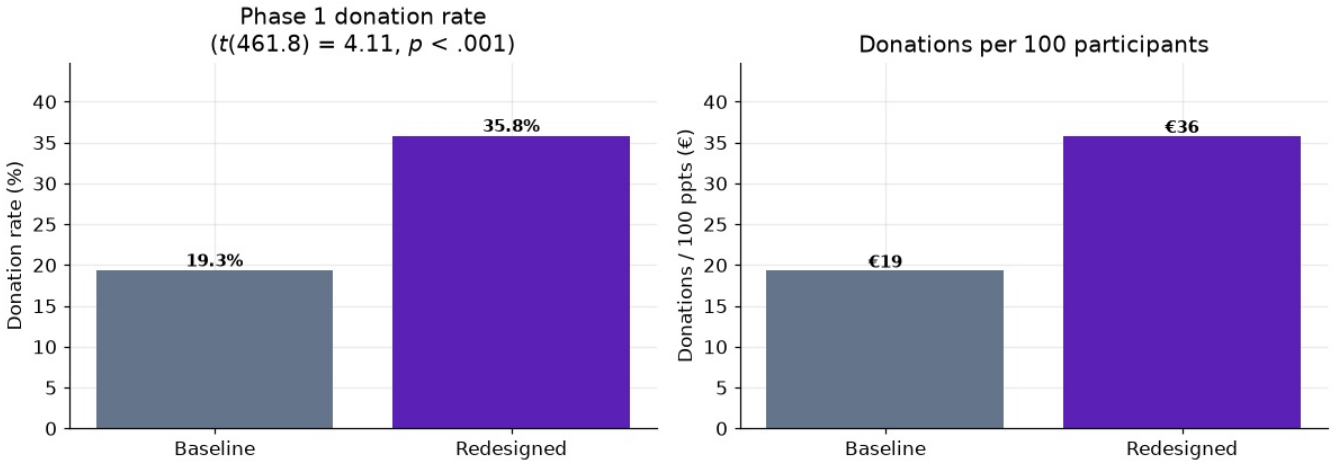
Phase 2. Each group saw a single fixed amount that it could accept or decline: €1.00 (Low-Amount), €10.00 (High-Amount), or €5.00 (Round-Up, which rounded the booking total up to the next multiple of €10). None of the groups was forced-choice.

Results

Phase 1. With the donation amount fixed at €1.00 for both groups, the Redesigned prompt raised the donation rate from 19.3% to 35.8%, an increase of 16.5 percentage points, $t(461.8) = 4.11$, $p < .001$, $d = 0.37$ (Figure 7).

Figure 7

Experiment 3: Phase 1 donation rate and donations per 100 participants.



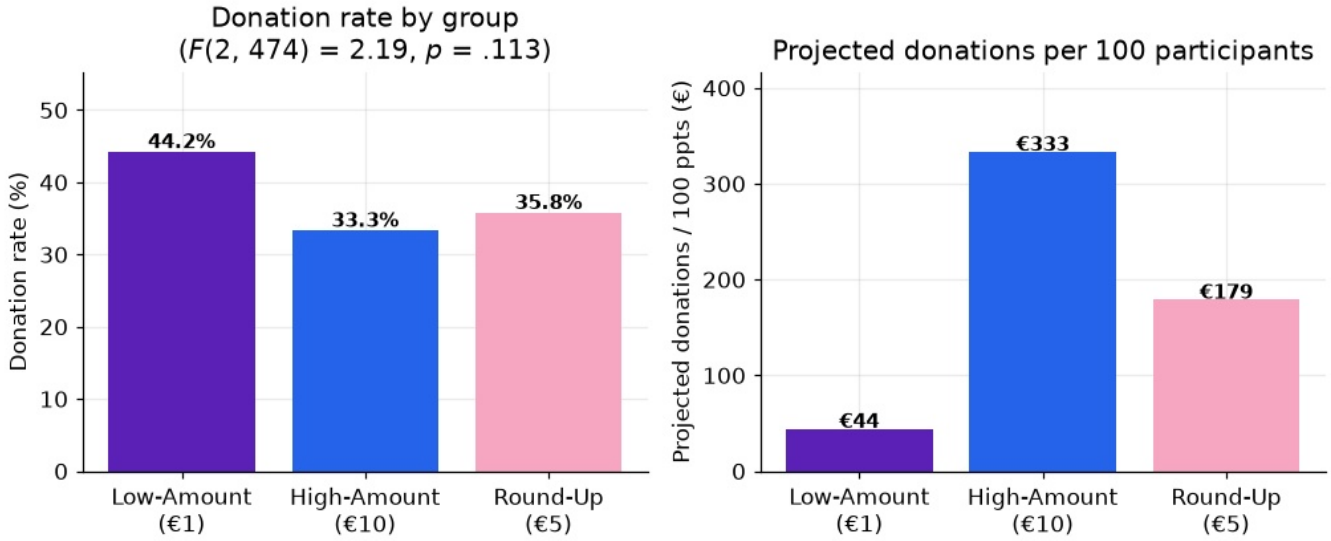
Baseline $n = 243$ (SOS Children's Villages, checkbox pop-up), Redesigned $n = 240$ (Rainforest Trust, Redesigned prompt); both amounts fixed at €1.00.

Brand Perception Measures. The difference in composite brand perception scores did not reach statistical significance (4.59 for the Baseline group vs 4.69 for the Redesigned group), $t(473.5) = 1.10$, $p = .270$, $d = 0.10$.

Phase 2. Donation rates were 44.2% for Low-Amount, 33.3% for High-Amount, and 35.8% for Round-Up (Figure 8). The overall difference did not reach statistical significance, $F(2, 474) = 2.19$, $p = .113$, $\eta^2 = .01$. Projected donations per 100 participants were €44.23, €333.33, and €179.01, so the €10 request would hypothetically raise 7.54 times as much as the €1 request. The hypothetical-to-real donation ratio was 1.23.

Figure 8

Experiment 3: Phase 2 donation rate and projected donations per 100 participants by fixed donation amount.



Identical Rainforest Trust prompt in all groups; only the amount differed (€1, €10, or round-up = €5).

Charity Preferences. Participants answered two charity preference questions after finishing Phase 2. When asked which charitable cause they would most willingly support when booking a flight, the most common response was "None / prefer not to donate" (180 of 477); among the remainder, environmental causes led (126), followed by children and youth programs (78), health and medical causes (56), and community causes (37). Among the 126 respondents preferring environmental causes, climate action led (63), followed by wildlife conservation (29), rewilding and habitat restoration (17), rainforest conservation (9), and ocean and marine conservation (8).

General Discussion

Many airlines already ask customers to donate at checkout. Customers who donate at checkout report positive feelings associated with the donation and are more likely to return to the business (Giebelhausen *et al.*, 2017). Programs that tie a purchase to a cause reliably improve consumer attitudes and purchase intentions (Bhattacharya and Sen, 2003; Schamp *et al.*, 2023), which is part of why checkout campaigns have become common practice in retail (Engage for Good, 2025; Sudbury and Vossler, 2022). The current research examined how the design of that donation request affects a passenger's willingness to donate.

Across three airline booking simulations that differed in fare, charity, and checkout structure, the Baseline donation opt-in rates were similar (18.6%, 17.8%, and 19.3%). The redesigned donation feature increased uptake in each experiment, to 29.7%, 26.4%, and 35.8%. Across three different booking contexts, a better invitation at the moment of booking produced more real giving. Differences in composite brand perception did not reach statistical significance in any experiment.

The Phase 1 results carry the most weight because the giving was consequential. Every donation came out of an allowance the participant would otherwise have kept, so each of the 1,683 Phase 1 decisions was a choice about the participant's own money. Under those conditions 455 participants gave. Research on climate giving in air travel has relied mostly on what people say they would be willing to pay (Lu and Shon, 2012; SITA, 2022).

The redesigned request worked by bringing more people in. Mean donation among donors differed little between groups (£1.00 and £1.10 in Experiment 1; £2.35 and £2.43 in Experiment 2; fixed at €1.00 in Experiment 3), while real donations per 100 participants were £18.60 and £32.76 in Experiment 1, £41.91 and £64.02 in Experiment 2, and €19.34 and €35.83 in Experiment 3. The additional money therefore came mainly from additional donors.

Experiment 2 also tested the addition of a required response together with a highlighted £2 amount. The redesigned request alone raised opt-in from 17.8% to 26.4%. When the request also required participants to accept or decline and highlighted £2, opt-in reached 41.8%. The difference in composite brand perception did not reach statistical significance in either case. Whether a required response is acceptable in a live checkout is a question for field testing (Zou *et al.*, 2026).

In an exploratory comparison of the same request with and without real money at stake, participants opted in more often when the donation was hypothetical, but only by a factor of 1.1–1.5. Stated willingness to donate therefore exceeded real giving, but by a modest margin for this request. These descriptive comparisons motivate further tests of whether donation-request design affects the gap between hypothetical and consequential choices.

This research clearly and consistently demonstrates a proof of concept for a successful donation-at-checkout model. However, the bookings were simulated, and although Phase 1 donations reduced the allowance participants could keep, the airline fares were not paid during the current research, so our participants were not customers who had just committed hundreds of dollars to a flight. Furthermore, the higher donation amounts requested in Phase 2 remained hypothetical. It remains untested whether airline travelers would show more price sensitivity when asked to donate larger amounts of their own money. Given that nobody in these studies could abandon a booking to buy tickets elsewhere, we cannot say whether the updated donation feature has the potential to cost ticket sales, even though brand perception measures are not significantly different when the donation feature is updated. These questions require live implementation.

People often say they want to support climate action, but those intentions are often not translated into action. These experiments show that the moment of booking offers an opportunity to narrow that gap. An improved donation feature increased real charitable giving in all three airline booking flows, which meant more money for the causes people care about. Airlines can implement these changes now through checkout and payment systems they already use. The redesign requires little new infrastructure and could begin generating significant and impactful funding immediately, while longer-term sustainability solutions continue to develop and scale.

Recommendations

Three recommendations follow for an airline running a checkout donation feature. All of them are likely to be inexpensive to implement and use payment architecture the airline already has, and they are informed by patterns observed across booking flows that otherwise differ in fare, charity and checkout structure.

1. *Redesign the request.* The redesigned version reported how many other travelers had already given, stated plainly where the money goes, and carried an image of the cause. The complete redesign packages tested here increased donation opt-in rates.
2. *Ask for more.* In hypothetical choices, higher requests raised projected donations 2.7 to 7.5 times; whether this holds with customers' own money should be tested.
3. *Monitor brand perceptions during live testing.* The difference in composite brand perception did not reach statistical significance in any experiment. Live tests should assess brand perceptions alongside donation revenue and booking completion.

References

Berger, S., Kilchenmann, A., Lenz, O. and Schlöder, F. (2022), "Willingness-to-pay for carbon dioxide offsets: field evidence on revealed preferences in the aviation industry", *Global Environmental Change*, Vol. 73, 102470. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.gloenvcha.2022.102470

Bhattacharya, C.B. and Sen, S. (2003), "Consumer-company identification: a framework for understanding consumers' relationships with companies", *Journal of Marketing*, Vol. 67 No. 2, pp. 76-88. https://doi.org/10.1509/jmkg.67.2.76.18609

Blanchard, L., Anderegg, W.R.L. and Haya, B.K. (2024), "Instead of carbon offsets, we need 'contributions' to forests", Stanford Social Innovation Review, 31 January, available at: https://ssir.org/articles/entry/forest-contributions-carbon-offsets (accessed 18 September 2026).

De Bruyn, A. and Prokopec, S. (2013), "Opening a donor's wallet: the influence of appeal scales on likelihood and magnitude of donation", *Journal of Consumer Psychology*, Vol. 23 No. 4, pp. 496-502. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jcps.2013.03.004

Engage for Good (2025), "America's charity checkout champions", available at: https://engageforgood.com/resource/americas-charity-checkout-champions/ (accessed 18 September 2026).

Giebelhausen, M., Lawrence, B., Chun, H.H. and Hsu, L. (2017), "The warm glow of restaurant checkout charity", *Cornell Hospitality Quarterly*, Vol. 58 No. 4, pp. 329-341. https://doi.org/10.1177/1938965517704533

Gneezy, U., Keenan, E.A. and Gneezy, A. (2014), "Avoiding overhead aversion in charity", *Science*, Vol. 346 No. 6209, pp. 632-635. https://doi.org/10.1126/science.1253932

Goldstein, N.J., Cialdini, R.B. and Griskevicius, V. (2008), "A room with a viewpoint: using social norms to motivate environmental conservation in hotels", *Journal of Consumer Research*, Vol. 35 No. 3, pp. 472-482. https://doi.org/10.1086/586910

Harris, N.L., Gibbs, D.A., Baccini, A., Birdsey, R.A., de Bruin, S., Farina, M., Fatoyinbo, L., Hansen, M.C., Herold, M., Houghton, R.A., Potapov, P.V., Suarez, D.R., Roman-Cuesta, R.M., Saatchi, S.S., Slay, C.M., Turubanova, S.A. and Tyukavina, A. (2021), "Global maps of twenty-first century forest carbon fluxes", *Nature Climate Change*, Vol. 11 No. 3, pp. 234-240. https://doi.org/10.1038/s41558-020-00976-6

Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (2022), *Climate Change 2022: Mitigation of Climate Change. Contribution of Working Group III to the Sixth Assessment Report of the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change*, Shukla, P.R., Skea, J., Slade, R., Al Khourdajie, A., van Diemen, R., McCollum, D., Pathak, M., Some, S., Vyas, P., Fradera, R., Belkacemi,

M., Hasija, A., Lisboa, G., Luz, S. and Malley, J. (Eds), Cambridge University Press, Cambridge, UK and New York, NY, USA. https://doi.org/10.1017/9781009157926

International Air Transport Association (2026), "Sustainable aviation fuels (SAF) fact sheet", IATA, available at: https://www.iata.org/en/iata-repository/pressroom/fact-sheets/fact-sheet-sustainable-aviation-fuels/ (accessed 18 September 2026).

Johnson, E.J. and Goldstein, D. (2003), "Do defaults save lives?", *Science*, Vol. 302 No. 5649, pp. 1338-1339. https://doi.org/10.1126/science.1091721

Kelting, K., Robinson, S. and Lutz, R.J. (2019), "Would you like to round up and donate the difference? Roundup requests reduce the perceived pain of donating", *Journal of Consumer Psychology*, Vol. 29 No. 1, pp. 70-78. https://doi.org/10.1002/jcpy.1064

Lee, S. and Feeley, T.H. (2017), "A meta-analysis of the pique technique of compliance", *Social Influence*, Vol. 12 No. 1, pp. 15-28. https://doi.org/10.1080/15534510.2017.1305986

Lu, J.-L. and Shon, Z.Y. (2012), "Exploring airline passengers' willingness to pay for carbon offsets", *Transportation Research Part D: Transport and Environment*, Vol. 17 No. 2, pp. 124-128. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.trd.2011.10.002

Probst, B.S., Toetzke, M., Kontoleon, A., Díaz Anadón, L., Minx, J.C., Haya, B.K., Schneider, L., Trotter, P.A., West, T.A.P., Gill-Wiehl, A. and Hoffmann, V.H. (2024), "Systematic assessment of the achieved emission reductions of carbon crediting projects", *Nature Communications*, Vol. 15 No. 1, 9562. https://doi.org/10.1038/s41467-024-53645-z

Santos, M.D., Leve, C. and Pratkanis, A.R. (1994), "Hey buddy, can you spare seventeen cents? Mindful persuasion and the pique technique", *Journal of Applied Social Psychology*, Vol. 24 No. 9, pp. 755-764. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1559-1816.1994.tb00610.x

Schamp, C., Heitmann, M., Bijmolt, T.H.A. and Katzenstein, R. (2023), "The effectiveness of cause-related marketing: a meta-analysis on consumer responses", *Journal of Marketing Research*, Vol. 60 No. 1, pp. 189-215. https://doi.org/10.1177/00222437221109782

SITA (2022), *Passenger IT Insights 2022*, SITA, available at: https://www.sita.aero/resources/surveys-reports/passenger-it-insights-2022/ (accessed 28 September 2026).

Sudbury, A.W. and Vossler, C.A. (2022), "Checking out checkout charity: a study of point-of-sale donation campaigns", *Journal of Economic Behavior & Organization*, Vol. 204, pp. 252-270. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jebo.2022.10.026

Thaler, R.H. and Sunstein, C.R. (2008), *Nudge: Improving Decisions About Health, Wealth, and Happiness*, Yale University Press, New Haven, CT.

White, K., Habib, R. and Hardisty, D.J. (2019), "How to SHIFT consumer behaviors to be more sustainable: a literature review and guiding framework", *Journal of Marketing*, Vol. 83 No. 3, pp. 22-49. https://doi.org/10.1177/0022242919825649

YouGov (2023), "Need to fly greener: most consumers say airlines aren't doing enough to reduce environmental impact", available at: https://yougov.com/articles/47590-need-to-fly-greener-most-consumers-say-airlines-arent-doing-enough-to-reduce-environmental-impact (accessed 18 September 2026).

Zou, Y., Matthews, D., Rao Hill, S. and Hoffmann, A.O.I. (2026), "Doing good but feeling bad: how checkout donation requests might backfire for retailers by eliciting negative emotional and cognitive consumer response", *Journal of Retailing and Consumer Services*, Vol. 90, 104673. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jretconser.2025.104673

Appendix. Brand and Attitude Measures

These four items were asked after Phase 1 and before Phase 2. Airline names in the first four items below were replaced by the airline used in the booking flow. Each item used a seven-point scale with the endpoints shown.

1. Based on this experience, how favorable is your opinion of [airline]? (1 = Very unfavorable, 7 = Very favorable)
2. Based on this experience, how likely would you be to use [airline] in the future? (1 = Very unlikely, 7 = Very likely)
3. Based on this experience, how likely would you be to consider [airline] even if it was not the cheapest? (1 = Very unlikely, 7 = Very likely)
4. How does the inclusion of a climate donation option affect your willingness to book with this airline? (1 = makes me LESS likely to book, 7 = makes me MORE likely to book)

Composite favorability is the mean of favorability, future use, consideration when not cheapest, and willingness to book, requiring all four answers. No item is attributed to Phase 2.